

Projects

"Computer Says No" - Disability Benefits under AI Governance



Applying for Government Disability Benefits is a complex process, extremely important but inaccessible to many. This is still an ongoing project and we are trying to disentangle this system with 40 people living with aphasia and offer more meaningful engagement. So far, we know that the current system contrains peoples' agency to contest top-down automatisisation changes (ie., RoboCall). Most of these barriers are deeply embedded in digital infrastructures: denial of support, dehumanising assessments and prolonged burocratic limbo. The workload placed on applicants routinely exceeds cognitive and energy budgets, breaching basic fairness, accessibility, and equal opportunity. Transparency is weak. People reject the idea that AI will seamlessly resolve these matters as current AI models have sharp knowledge boundaries.

Help Card front

PIP (Personal Independence Payment) HELP

Help Card reverse

For long-term physical or mental health conditions or disabilities that make it difficult to carry out daily living activities or get around. Stroke is a common condition for PIP claims. It's not means-tested (your savings or earnings don't matter). It's assessed by private contractors on a points-based system. It has two components: DAILY LIVING (everyday tasks like washing and dressing, but also includes communication) and MOBILITY (getting around). Getting the enhanced mobility component grants access to the Mobility scheme. PIP may also lead to an increase in other benefits or automatic entitlement to additional benefits.

Feelings card

-- (very negative) FEELINGS

Deployed design materials

Workshops online & in-person

Ranking Help cards toolkit

15pm P4 phones DWP call e for assistance, relying on o input and process his UC migration over the phone

7:45pm

From the outset, threatening terms and conditions were read aloud in legalistic language - heightening stress

7:45pm

Poor local mobile coverage prevents P4 from taking the call at home

7:45pm

Automated robocalls repeatedly misinterpreted his speech, cutting him off; he had to verbally spell his name, phone number and answer six security questions

7:45pm

Lengthy security checks required extensive phone keypad input

7:45pm

Extended holds repeatedly instructed him to 'go online' despite his aphasia

7:45pm

P4 was required to recall obscure details—including addresses, adjusted rent figures, and employment histories—facts difficult for anyone to summon insta but particularly onerous for someone with aphasia—situation was compounded by the Southern Housir Association phone line being unavailable

7:45pm

When his call dropped unexpectedly at 6pm, he was told to restart the entire process the next day

7:45pm

Ultimately, he was attended th Centre in person to finalise his migration, undermining the v premise of digital access

7:45pm

P4 performing keypad entry